

Episode 97: Once Upon a Time... (59) – *COO* The Darkness of Southern Island Nights is...

It's August! August. Soon it'll be "late summer greetings," but how is everyone doing?

Thanks to everyone, I'm spending a summer so busy it brings tears to my eyes. Ah, I love work. Goodbye, summer days (sobbing).

My work this summer includes first the currently broadcasting *Ultimate!! Mecha-Mote Chairman* (極上！ めちゃモチ委員長) on TV Tokyo network. This one's tough. I'm constantly battling with all the fashionable elements appearing every week.

Several other TV works are in motion, but they're still secret. I can't write about them, sorry.

And theatrical works. The current big project is a pirate movie opening this winter - the theatrical *ONE PIECE*:

STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM

Advance tickets just went on sale recently, with various information being released.

This year is the commemorative 10th movie, so original creator Oda Eiichiro serves as executive producer. He wrote an original story and created a massive amount of character concepts. The staff working hard to turn these into even more wonderful visuals includes animation director and character designer Sato Masayuki, art director Waki Takeshi from Studio Green, art setting Sato Masahiro, colour design by me, and directing all this staff is Chief Director Sakai Munehisa from the TV series.

Actually, Sakai-kun served as production manager on the movie *Coo: Far From Home* that I'm rambling about in these "Colour Design Notes." I'm making this exciting masterpiece with such a Sakai-kun. Please look forward to it!

Now then.

"Since they're attacking on a moonless night, wouldn't darkness be more atmospheric? So dark you can't see (laughs)," said I. This is about the climactic scene in the first half of *Coo: Far From Home* where special forces attack Yosuke and the others to kidnap Coo.

Coo: Far From Home has several night scenes. Since island scenes basically aimed for a "heartwarming" relaxed feeling, night scenes were also made quietly and peacefully, but from this "attack scene" onward we decided to aim for tension. My comment in that meeting was the above.

The darkest scene is around the infiltration from midnight jungle to Yosuke and the others' house. Then Cathy and Yosuke waiting inside the house. They successfully repel the attackers once. Around that area.

"Night" expression probably varies tremendously by work, but it's often made relatively bright. Why? Because if it's too pitch black, you can't tell what's happening on screen (laughs). So when creating so-called "night colours," we decide colour tones considering such things along with brightness balance and screen atmosphere.

But in this case, I thought it might be better if it was unclear enough. Special forces are attacking under cover of darkness, and waiting Cathy and others would be in trouble if seen. I thought from the perspective and feelings of Yosuke and others holding their breath in that place, or the special force members, rather than us watching the screen. It was one attempt to somehow bring moviegoers into feeling like they're inside that screen.

Therefore, this "attack scene" became the darkest scene in the main story for both backgrounds and cels. The actual scene was short, and with night vision goggle green screens interspersed, the series of action performances were clearly understandable, and I calculated that with 35mm film screen depth, we could make it quite dark and be fine.

The scenes following this "attack scene" were the same. I created screens following the brightness and visibility from the perspective of Yosuke and others in that location.

The blinding brightness of combat helicopter lights. The dark figures of special forces trying to take Coo away against the gradually dawning subtle blue sky. In pre-dawn darkness, Tony's Cessna attacking from above is already in dawn brightness, with aerial combat there. Following that, Yosuke and the dolphins pursuing the special forces boat are already in pre-sunrise brightness. And Blue's tragedy.

I think we created a good feeling for the rapid series of scenes riding on Yosuke and others' subjective perspective.

As a postscript, considerably after the release, when *Coo: Far From Home* was broadcast on Nippon Television, this "attack scene" was beautifully pitch black (laughs). It really wasn't visible on TV.

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